

EXECUTIVE BRIEF

Satellites Need Ground Truth

What leaders should authorize, require, and refuse

Production Unit	PU-B07-C15
Decision status	Controlled learning asset
Audience	Executives, programme owners, statisticians, technical leads
Data	Synthetic examples only

Executive takeaway: Integrate remote-sensing evidence only after documenting spatial resolution, temporal alignment, cloud and sensor limits, ground truth, and uncertainty.

Why it matters

Satellite signals can be visually persuasive while measuring the wrong land cover, season, geography, or agricultural condition.

Illustrative application

A vegetation anomaly is checked against field observations and crop masks before it informs a production-risk brief.

Minimum approval conditions

- Named accountable owner and lawful purpose
- Defined evidence, provenance, reference period, population, and geography
- Decision-relevant validation and visible uncertainty
- Documented abstention, referral, override, and incident processes
- Accessibility, equity, security, retention, and retirement review

Non-negotiable boundary

The analytical system may inform review. It may not independently authorize benefits, sanctions, enforcement, clinical treatment, school exclusion, displacement, or another consequential action.